



Kuwait



Kuwait lies at the northwest tip of the Gulf, dwarfed by its neighbors Iraq, Iran, and Saudi Arabia. It was a British protectorate until 1961, when full independence was granted.



GEOGRAPHY

Terrain is low-lying desert. The lowest land is in the north. Cultivation is only possible along the coast.



CLIMATE

Summers are very hot and dry. Winters are cooler, with some rain and occasional frost at night.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

Oil-rich monarchy, ruled by the al-Sabah family. It is a conservative Sunni Muslim society, but women are relatively free. Nonetheless, a 1999 decree giving women the vote was blocked for six years in parliament by Islamic traditionalists. Immigrant workers, from other Arab states, India, and Pakistan, now outnumber native citizens. US-led forces rescued Kuwait after the 1990 Iraqi invasion, and later used it as a launchpad for the 2003 invasion to oust Saddam Hussein.



THE ECONOMY

Oil and natural gas dominate the economy. Skilled workforce, raw materials, and food are imported. High standard of living. Financial services: stock market lost 40% of value in 2008.



INSIGHT: During the 1991 Gulf War, Iraq deliberately set fire to 800 of Kuwait's 950 oil wells



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: State of Kuwait

DATE OF FORMATION: 1961

CAPITAL: Kuwait City

POPULATION: 2.99 million

TOTAL AREA: 6880 sq. miles
(17,820 sq. km)

DENSITY: 434 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Arabic*, English

RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 45%, Shi'a Muslim 40%, Christian, Hindu, and other 15%

ETHNIC MIX: Kuwaiti 45%, other Arab 35%, South Asian 9%, other 11%

GOVERNMENT: Monarchy

CURRENCY: Kuwaiti dinar = 1000 fils